for short-range as well as for long-range missiles. (No one in Washington dreamed that the Soviet soldiers might be equipped with tactical nukes.) Most alarming: in the event that the communications link with Moscow might be severed, Soviet field commanders were authorized to use tactical nukes against an American invasion.

This last observations startled, and appalled, the Americans present. I was sitting next to Robert McNamara, our Secretary of Defense during the crisis, and he almost fell out of his chair. The American Joint Chiefs of Staff (not McNamara, however) had been all-out for invasion. Had their advice prevailed, as McNamara later said, nuclear war would have begun on the beaches of Cuba and might have ended in a global holocaust.

How did we Americans get ourselves and the world into this fix? By 1962 Castro's Cuba was well established as a designated enemy of the United States. Two years earlier the Eisenhower administration had hired members of the Mafia to assassinate Castro and had begun training anti-Castro Cuban exiles for an invasion of their homeland. The Kennedy administration inherited the project that led to the Bay of Pigs. After this misbegotten affair, the Kennedy administration sponsored a CIA campaign of harassment and sabotage. In Havana and in Moscow Operation Mongoose was taken, not unreasonably, as preparation for invasion by U.S. forces.

Castro, again not unreasonably, turned to the Soviet Union as Cuba's protector. He hoped, through a proclamation or an alliance or Soviet conventional military aid, to deter American aggression. He did not request, nor did he want, nuclear missiles. This was Khrushchev's idea. "When Castro and I talked about the problem," Khrushchev recalled in his memoirs, "we argued and argued. Our argument was very heated. But, in the end, Fidel agreed with me."[1]

Castro reluctantly accepted nuclear missiles, as he later said, "not in order to ensure our own defense, but primarily to strengthen socialism on the international plane." He then asked Khrushchev to go public when he delivered the missiles. "Why do it secretly—as if we had no right to do it?" After all, the Soviet Union had every right under international law to send the missiles and Cuba had every right to receive them. "I warned Nikita that secrecy would hand the imperialists the advantage."[2]

Fortunately for the imperialists Khrushchev did not follow Castro's advice. Had he done so, it would have been far harder to force the